

When I inherited a previous neighbor's stash of trash, you'd have thought I'd won the lottery. After we carted it all home, I spent hours on my back porch sorting through it all: rubber-banding box tops and box bottoms together, filling a bin with empty M&M candy bags, and taping and paper-clipping small proofs of purchase to blank note cards. That winter I was able to order a dozen strings of M&M Christmas lights and at least as many \$5 AT&T gift certificates with my inheritance. Every time I visited my parents, I came home with Folgers' lids and Del Monte labels my mother had saved for me. When Folgers offered a free coffeemaker, I ordered one for her, another for myself, and had yet another sent to my sister's house for her family. When the Gloria Vanderbilt Company offered a lovely feminine umbrella in exchange for an empty box, I didn't have to purchase any perfume since I had two flattened boxes in my file cabinet. The majority of the offers didn't require a receipt, but I saved every one of my receipts and picked others up from the parking lot, just in case. Our small-town grocery store didn't have itemized receipts, so if a refund required a cash register tape, I either used one I had stapled to the empty box or included one from the grocery store with the approximate price.